

Welcome to Magpie

Magpie helps you get organised with the files already on your computer — photos, videos, scans, PDFs, whatever you keep. You point it at a folder, and it shows you every file inside that has room for tags. From there you can:

- Give a file a **name** and add **tags** — short labels like `beach`, `Christmas`, or `contract` — so you can find groups of files in seconds later on.
- Look at everything the file already knows about itself — resolution, camera, when it was taken, page count for PDFs — right next to the file.
- Delete the ones you don't want any more.

Everything stays on your computer. Nothing is uploaded, no account is needed, and you can keep using Magpie with no internet connection.

Why use Magpie?

Most people end up with files scattered across folders like `Camera Roll`, `iPhone Backup 2019`, and `Family - Copy (2)`. Windows gives you those folders and not much more. Magpie gives you a proper way to sort through them:

- **Find things fast.** Type `beach` in the search box and every file you tagged with `beach` shows up, no matter which folder it's in.
- **Nothing gets moved or modified.** Your files stay exactly where they are on disk, byte-for-byte unchanged. Tags are saved in Magpie's own database file in your Windows AppData folder.
- **One tool for all your files.** Photos, videos, and documents all live in the same library, side by side, with the same tag search.

A quick tour, in under two minutes

1. **Click "+ Add folder"** at the top of the window and pick a folder full of files. Magpie gets to work reading everything it finds.
2. **Scroll** through the files in the big central area — it stays smooth even with tens of thousands.
3. **Click a file** to open the details panel on the right. Type a title. Add a tag. Everything saves as you go — there's no "Save" button to remember.

4. **Hold Ctrl while clicking** to pick several files at once, then add the same tag to all of them.
5. **Type in the search box** at the top to find files by their tag, title, or filename.

That's the whole app in a nutshell. The rest of this manual explains each part in a bit more detail.

What Magpie is *not*

- **Not an editor.** It won't crop, straighten, retouch, or convert your files. Use another app for that.
- **Not a backup service.** Your files stay on your computer. If your hard drive fails, Magpie can't help — copy your files somewhere safe (an external drive, OneDrive, etc.).
- **Not a face-recogniser.** It won't guess who's in your photos or auto-tag them.

If you want any of those, Magpie is happy to sit next to whichever tool does them for you — it won't get in the way.

Installing and launching Magpie

What you need

- A PC running **Windows 10** or **Windows 11**.
- About **50 MB of free space** for the app.
- A little extra space for small thumbnail images (roughly 100 MB for every 10,000 files).

That's it. No account, no internet connection, no subscription.

Installing

Depending on where you got Magpie from, you'll have one of these:

- **An installer** (a file ending in `.msi` or `.exe`). Double-click it and follow the prompts. When Windows asks whether to allow the installer to make changes, click **Yes**.
- **A portable version** (just `desktop.exe`). Copy it wherever you like — for example, `C:\Programs\Magpie\` — and double-click it to launch. No installation needed.

If Windows shows a blue “Windows protected your PC” screen, click **More info** and then **Run anyway**. This happens with any small app that hasn't paid Microsoft for a code signature — it doesn't mean anything is wrong.

The very first time you open it

When you first start Magpie you'll see:

- An empty window with a friendly **“Add folder”** button.
- The status bar at the bottom saying **Idle**.

Nothing is scanned yet. Nothing is stored yet. Magpie is waiting for you to point it at a folder.

The [next chapter](#) walks you through that in detail.

What Magpie creates on your computer

Magpie keeps its own little workshop in a hidden Windows folder. You don't need to open it or think about it — but if you're curious, it's here:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder contains Magpie's own database (an index of the files it knows about) and small thumbnail previews. **None of your original files live there** — they stay exactly where you put them.

Uninstalling

- Installed with an `.msi` ? Open **Settings > Apps > Installed apps**, find Magpie, and click **Uninstall**.
- Portable version? Just delete `desktop.exe`.

To also wipe Magpie's own files, delete the hidden folder above (in File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar). **Your files and any tags you added to writable formats are safe** — those live in your folders, not in Magpie's workshop.

Adding your first folder

Magpie needs to know which folders on your computer contain the files you want to organise. Once you tell it, it does the rest.

Add a folder in three clicks

1. Click **+ Add folder** at the top of the window.
2. In the dialog that opens, browse to the folder that has your files — for example `C:\Users\me\Pictures\Vacation 2024`.
3. Click **Select folder**.

That's it. Magpie starts looking through the folder right away. The bar at the bottom of the window shows what's happening ("Reading 234 of 1,205 files...") and updates as it goes.

You don't have to wait for it to finish — files appear in the window as they're found, so you can start browsing (and even tagging) straight away.

What Magpie does when you add a folder

Behind the scenes, Magpie:

- **Remembers the folder in its own database.** Nothing is written inside your folder — the database lives in Magpie's own workshop area (`%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\magpie.db`). See [Where your data lives](#).
- **Looks in the folder and every folder inside it.** So adding `Pictures` also picks up `Pictures\2020`, `Pictures\Kids`, and so on. Video and document files are picked up too — see [Supported file formats](#).
- **Reads the built-in info** each file exposes: dimensions, camera, duration, page count, and so on.
- **Reads any tags or titles** already saved with the file (for example, tags you added earlier in Windows Explorer or Adobe Bridge) and imports them into Magpie's database. This is a one-time import.
- **Makes small thumbnail previews** for images so the grid loads instantly, even for very large libraries.

Your original files are **not moved, renamed, or changed** in any way during this. Magpie only reads them.

If the folder is on OneDrive, Dropbox, or a network share

Any drive works, including OneDrive, Dropbox, iCloud Drive, Google Drive, and network shares. Magpie's database is stored on your local PC in the Windows AppData folder, so cloud sync clients don't touch it. If you use Magpie on more than one PC, each PC has its own database — tag edits made on one don't automatically appear on the other.

Adding more folders

You can add as many folders as you like — one for your holidays, one for family, one for work documents, whatever suits you.

Every folder you add appears under **Library › Folders** in the left-hand sidebar. Click a folder name there to see only the files inside that folder.

Removing a folder

Right-click the folder name in the sidebar and choose **Remove from library**. Magpie forgets about it — but **your files stay on your computer, untouched**. If you later add the folder to Magpie again, its files are picked up fresh, and any tags that were already saved inside the files (from Windows Explorer, Lightroom, or a previous Magpie session) are imported one more time. Tags that only lived in Magpie's database for that folder are gone with the removal.

Removing a folder from Magpie is not the same as deleting it from your PC.

Refreshing when files change

If you drop new files into a folder using File Explorer, or edit some in another app, Magpie doesn't know about it right away. To catch up:

- **Right-click a folder name** in the sidebar and choose **Rescan folder**, or
- Click **Rescan** at the top of the window to check every folder at once.

Rescanning is quick — Magpie only looks at files that have changed since the last time it checked.

Browsing your library

The big area in the middle of the window is your **file grid**. It shows every file Magpie knows about, all in one long scrollable page. Even with tens of thousands of files, it stays smooth to scroll.

Picking files

- **Click a file** to select it. It gets a blue outline, and its details appear in the panel on the right.
- **Ctrl + click** more files to add them to the selection.
- **Shift + click** somewhere else in the grid to grab everything between the first and the new click.
- **Ctrl + A** picks every file currently shown.
- **Esc** unpicks everything.

The number of selected files is shown in the panel on the right and in the status bar at the bottom.

Sorting the grid

There's a **Sort** menu in the top bar. Choose what makes sense for the moment:

- **Taken** — when the file was taken/created (from the file itself). Great for going through a trip in order.
- **Filename** — A to Z by name.
- **Added** — the day the file was added to your library.
- **Size** — largest or smallest first.

The little arrow next to the sort menu flips between ascending and descending.

The details panel on the right

Click a file and its details appear on the right, split into four sections:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name.

2. **Tags** — labels you add for grouping and searching.
3. **Format metadata** — which handler Magpie is using and whether it can save your edits into the file itself.
4. **File info** — read-only technical information (size, resolution, camera, duration, page count...). What appears here depends on the file type.

Editing any of the top two sections saves automatically — no Save button. The next chapter, [Editing metadata](#), goes into detail.

If you pick more than one file at once, the details panel switches into a batch mode — see [Working on many files at once](#).

The sidebar filters

The list on the left is a set of filters — clicking one narrows down the grid to just matching files.

- **Library › Folders:** show only files from one specific folder on your computer.
- **Tags:** show only files with a specific tag. The number next to each tag is how many files have that tag.

Filters stack. Click a folder **and** a tag and you see only files that match both. Add words to the search box at the top for even finer results.

Clearing filters

Click **All photos** at the top of the sidebar to start fresh — every filter is cleared in one click.

Searching and filtering

Once you've added tags and titles to a good number of files, finding them again is a treat. Type a word or two in the search box at the top of the window and the grid narrows down to matching files while you type.

What the search looks at

The search box looks in three places on every file:

- The **title** you typed.
- The **tags** you added.
- The **filename** (like `IMG_4523.jpg` or `contract_signed.pdf`).

So if you type `sun`, Magpie finds files titled *Sunset*, tagged `sunny`, or in a file called `sunbathing.jpg`.

Capital letters don't matter: `Beach` and `beach` find the same files. Accents don't matter either: `naïve` finds files where you typed `naïve`.

Handy search tricks

- `beach vacation` — finds files with **both** words somewhere.
- `beach OR mountain` — finds files with **either** word.
- `vacation -beach` — vacation files that are **not** tagged beach.
- `"family reunion"` — the exact phrase, in that order.

You can even start typing part of a word — `sun` matches `sunset`, `sunny`, `sunbathing`.

Search + sidebar filters = laser-focused

The search box works together with the filters on the left. For example, to find *the Iceland files tagged glacier*:

1. Click the folder `Iceland` on the left.
2. Click the `glacier` tag in the Tags list.

The grid updates instantly. When you're done, click **All photos** in the sidebar to reset everything.

Clearing the search

Click the little ✕ inside the search box to clear it — or press **Esc** while your cursor is inside the box. The sidebar filters stay where they were.

Nothing found?

If a search turns up empty and you were expecting results:

- Check for a typo. `caht` won't find `cat` files.
- Try a shorter word. `mount` finds both `mountain` and `mountains`.
- Check the sidebar — you might have a filter active (like a folder or tag) that's excluding matches. Click **All photos** and try the search again.

Editing metadata

Metadata is a fancy word for “information about a file” — its title and tags. It’s what makes a folder of `IMG_1234.jpg` and `document_final_v3.pdf` files feel like a real library.

To edit any of this, click one file in the grid. The **details panel** on the right lights up with everything you can change.

What the panel shows

The details panel is split into four sections, top to bottom:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name (e.g. “Anna’s birthday cake”).
2. **Tags** — little labels like `beach`, `family`, `2024`, `contract`.
3. **Format metadata** — the name of the file’s format handler (JPEG, PNG, PDF, MP4, ...). This will grow as Magpie learns to edit more format-specific properties.
4. **File info** — everything Magpie learned from the file itself: size, resolution, when it was taken, camera used, page count, video duration, and so on. This section is read-only — those numbers describe the file, not your notes about it.

Everything saves as you type

There is **no Save button**. Magpie saves your changes automatically:

- **Title**: saved a moment after you stop typing (or as soon as you click somewhere else).
- **Tags**: saved immediately once you press space, Enter or comma.

You’ll see a tiny “Saving...” note when it’s happening. It usually takes less than half a second.

Setting a title

Click the **Title** box, type a name, click somewhere else (or wait a moment). Done.

To clear a title, just erase what’s there.

Adding tags

Click the **Tags** box. Type a word — for example `family` — and then press one of:

- **Space**
- **Enter**
- **Comma**

The tag becomes a little pill you can see. Type another word, press space, and there's another. Keep going for as many tags as you want.

While you type, Magpie suggests tags you've already used elsewhere, so you don't end up with `Beach`, `beach`, and `beaches` all meaning the same thing. Use the arrow keys to pick a suggestion and press Enter.

To **remove a tag**, hover over its pill and click the little ✕.

Every file is taggable

You can tag anything Magpie recognises — JPEG, PNG, RAW, HEIC, MP4, PDF, everything. There is no “this file type can't be tagged” warning, because tags never touch the source file: they live in Magpie's own database (see [Where your data lives](#)).

If a save fails

If a save fails, the panel shows a red note under the Tags field:

Save failed: *(the exact error)*

The usual culprits are a full disk or a second Magpie window running against the same account. Free up space or close the other window and re-edit the tag.

Working on many files at once

Editing files one at a time is fine when there are only a few. But when you have hundreds — say, an entire holiday — you'll want to tag them all in one go. Magpie is built for exactly that.

Picking several files

- **Click** the first file.
- **Ctrl + click** each of the other files you want to include.
- Or **Shift + click** at the far end to grab everything in between.
- **Ctrl + A** grabs every file in the current view.

The details panel on the right immediately switches to a batch view that reads *"N files selected"*. The number ticks up as you add more.

Adding tags to all of them

Batch mode shows two tag boxes:

- **Add tags** — anything you put here gets added to every selected file. Files that already had the tag are simply left alone.
- **Remove tags** — anything you put here gets removed from every selected file.

You can queue up multiple tags before hitting the button. When you're ready, click **Apply tag changes to N files**. A confirmation appears when it's done: *"Updated N files."*

Tip. Add tags in bulk first, then use the sidebar to check your work. Click the tag on the left — the grid narrows to just the files that have it, and you can see whether everything landed correctly.

Deleting them all at once

At the bottom of the details panel there's a red **Delete N files** button. Click it, confirm the prompt, and the whole selection heads to the Recycle Bin. See [Deleting files](#) for the full story.

What if one file won't accept a change?

Two cases where a file gets skipped:

1. **The folder is read-only** (an old backup drive, or something you pulled off a DVD). Fix the permissions on that folder (right-click → *Properties* in File Explorer) and try again.
2. **The file's format doesn't support embedded tags yet** (RAW, HEIC, PDF, video...). Magpie still remembers the tag in its own library, but it can't write it back into the file. The rest of the batch gets updated normally.

Either way, Magpie shows a message at the end telling you which files were skipped and why.

Tags: adding, renaming, cleaning up

Tags are little labels you stick on files so you can find them later. There are no folders-inside-folders or complicated structures — tags are just words. A file can have as many as you want.

Good tags are things you'd naturally think of later:

- **Places:** Iceland, beach, home.
- **People:** Emma, Grandad, the twins.
- **Events:** wedding, Christmas-2024, hike.
- **Feelings:** favourites, funny, to-print.

Adding tags

The most detailed walkthrough is in [Editing metadata](#). In short:

- Click the **Tags** box in the details panel.
- Type a word.
- Press **Space**, **Enter**, or **Comma** to save it.

Repeat as many times as you like. To **remove** a tag, click the little ✕ on its pill.

Capital letters don't matter — Beach and beach are treated as the same tag.

The tag list in the sidebar

Every tag you've ever used shows up in the **Tags** section of the sidebar on the left, in alphabetical order. Next to each tag is a number — how many files carry that tag.

- **Click a tag** to filter the grid to only files with that tag.
- **Right-click a tag** for two options: **Rename** and **Delete**.

Renaming a tag

Made a typo? Change your mind on capitalisation? Right-click the tag and choose **Rename tag**.... Type the new name and confirm.

Magpie updates the tag on **every file that had it**, all at once. There's no per-file work to do.

Deleting a tag

Right-click the tag → **Delete tag**. This removes the tag from every file — but it does not delete any files. Only the label goes.

Autocompletion — save yourself typos

While you type a new tag, Magpie shows a small dropdown of tags you've used before that start with the same letters. Use the arrow keys to pick one and press Enter. This is the easiest way to keep your tag list tidy — no more `beach`, `beaches`, `beach`, `beach-day`.

Tips for tagging a big library

- **Start broad.** Tag by place or year first — `Iceland`, `2024`. Once every file has broad tags, narrow ones (`glacier`, `Reykjavik`) are easier because you can filter down first.
- **Use multi-select.** `Ctrl + click` many files and add tags to them all in one go.
- **Don't over-tag.** A tag that's on 8,000 files isn't very useful. When in doubt, pick tags that would show fewer than a few hundred results.

Do tags show up in other apps?

No. Magpie stores every tag in its own database (`%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\magpie.db`); it does not write tags into the files themselves. Windows Explorer, Adobe Lightroom, etc. won't see tags you added in Magpie.

The upside is that Magpie **doesn't modify your files** and every file type is fully taggable. The downside is that if you want tags to travel with the file (email a JPEG to a friend and keep its tag visible in their photo viewer), you need to tag it in Explorer / Bridge instead. See [Interoperability with other tools](#) for the details.

Supported file formats

Magpie can put every file below into your library and let you tag and search it. **Every recognised file is fully taggable** — the tags just don't go into the file itself. They live in Magpie's own database in your Windows AppData folder; see [Where your data lives](#) for the details.

That means: **if Magpie shows the file in the grid, you can tag it.** No more “sorry, this format has no writable property handler” warning.

Images

- **JPEG** — .jpg, .jpeg, .jpe, .jfif
- **PNG** — .png
- **WebP** — .webp
- **GIF** — .gif
- **TIFF** — .tif, .tiff
- **HEIF family** — .heic, .heif, .hif, .avif
- **JPEG XL / JPEG XR / HD Photo** — .jxl, .jxr, .wdp
- **Older raster formats** — .bmp, .dib, .exr, .hdr, .hdp
- **JPEG 2000 family** — .jp2, .j2k, .j2c, .jpx, .jif
- **Vector** — .svg
- **Photoshop** — .psd, .psb

Camera RAW

- **Canon** — .cr2, .cr3, .crw
- **Nikon** — .nef, .nrw
- **Sony** — .arw, .sr2, .srf, .arq
- **Fuji** — .raf
- **Olympus** — .orf, .ori
- **Panasonic** — .rw2, .rw1
- **Pentax** — .pef
- **Samsung** — .srw
- **Sigma** — .x3f
- **Adobe / generic** — .dng

Video

- **MP4 family** — `.mp4`, `.m4v`, `.mov`, `.3gp`, `.3gpp`, `.3g2`
- **Legacy Windows** — `.wmv`, `.asf`
- **MPEG transport / Matroska / AVI** — `.ts`, `.mts`, `.m2ts`, `.mkv`, `.mks`, `.mka`, `.webm`, `.avi`, `.qt`

Documents

- **PDF** — `.pdf`

Existing tags in your files

If a JPEG (or any format above) already carries XMP tags from Adobe Bridge / Lightroom, or the Explorer *Properties* → *Details* dialog, Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan and imports them into the folder's database. From that point on you can edit the tags in Magpie freely — but Magpie will never write into the source file again. See [Interoperability with other tools](#).

Files Magpie ignores

Anything not in the tables above is skipped when you scan a folder. That's intentional — a system file or ZIP archive doesn't usually belong in a photo/video library.

If you want a new file type supported, that's a normal thing to ask for. The Magpie backend has a small “format handler” plug-in system so new types can be added without touching the rest of the app.

Deleting files

Sooner or later you'll want to get rid of some files — blurry shots, duplicates, an old draft PDF, that photo of a light switch from someone's pocket. Magpie deletes them safely, with a confirmation, and puts them in the **Recycle Bin** so you can undo the deletion if you change your mind.

Deleting one file

1. Click the file in the grid.
2. Either:
 - Click the red **Delete file** button at the bottom of the details panel, **or**
 - Press the **Delete** key on your keyboard.
3. A prompt asks: *"Move IMG_2043.jpg to the Recycle Bin?"*.
4. Click **Move to Recycle Bin** to confirm — or **Cancel** to back out.

The file disappears from Magpie and lands in the Windows Recycle Bin.

Deleting many files at once

1. Pick lots of files with **Ctrl + click** or **Shift + click**.
2. Click **Delete N files** at the bottom of the details panel (or press the **Delete** key).
3. Confirm the prompt.

What actually happens when you delete

- The file is moved to the **Windows Recycle Bin** — the same Recycle Bin you already know.
- Any tags Magpie had for that file go with it.
- Any leftover `.xmp` sidecar next to the file is deleted too.
- Magpie forgets the file (until you restore it — see below).

Nothing is deleted permanently — unless you tell it to (see the next section).

Getting a file back after deleting

Made a mistake? No problem:

1. Double-click the **Recycle Bin** on your desktop.
2. Find your file.
3. Right-click it → **Restore**.

The file goes back exactly where it was. The next time you click **Rescan** in Magpie, it re-appears in the library with its tags and title still on it.

Permanently deleting (no safety net)

If you're absolutely sure a file is gone-for-good, hold the **Shift** key while pressing Delete (or while clicking the delete button). The prompt will say *"Permanently delete"* instead of *"Move to Recycle Bin"*.

Warning. Permanent deletion cannot be undone. Do not use it unless you're 100% sure — and always keep a backup of important files.

If in doubt, use the normal delete. You can always empty the Recycle Bin later.

What is *not* deleted

- **Removing a folder from Magpie is not deleting.** The files stay on your computer.
- **Un-tagging is not deleting.** Removing every tag from a file just leaves it un-tagged.
- **A tag that no file uses any more** doesn't get deleted automatically. You can right-click it in the sidebar and choose **Delete tag** to clean it up.

Where your data lives

A quick, plain-language tour of what Magpie puts where. You don't need to know any of this to use the app — but many people like knowing exactly where their information ends up.

Your files

Your files stay where you put them. Magpie never moves, renames, or changes them. If you added `C:\Users\me\Pictures\Vacation 2024`, that's where the files still live, byte-for-byte the way they were.

Magpie never writes into your files. Older versions of Magpie tried to embed tags directly into JPEGs and PNGs. That approach caused problems (files got modified even when the user was just browsing, some formats couldn't be written to at all, cloud sync services would re-upload gigabytes for a one-word tag change). Magpie now leaves your files completely untouched.

Your tags and titles

Tags and titles live in one small database file that Magpie keeps in a hidden Windows folder:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\magpie.db
```

That single file remembers:

- Every folder you've added to Magpie.
- Every image Magpie has seen in each folder.
- The tags and title you've set for each image.
- A search index so typing in the search box is instant.
- Any smart searches (saved searches) you've created.

Every file becomes taggable. RAW files, videos, PDFs, HEIC, TIFF and every other format are all tagged the same way now, because the tags are in Magpie's database, not in the file.

Existing tags in your files

If your photos already carry XMP tags (from Lightroom, Bridge, or older versions of Magpie), or Windows Explorer keywords set through the *Properties* → *Details* tab, Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan and imports them into `magpie.db`. From that point on the database is the source of truth — later edits in Magpie stay in the database, and Magpie does **not** try to keep the file's embedded tags in sync.

If you also edit tags in Explorer or Lightroom, Magpie won't see those edits until you rescan the folder and manually reimport, so pick one tool as your master. See [Interoperability with other tools](#).

Folders on OneDrive, Dropbox, or a network share

You can put a Magpie folder on any drive, including cloud-synced locations like OneDrive, Dropbox, Google Drive, iCloud Drive, or a network share. The database file itself lives in your local `AppData\Roaming` folder (which Windows doesn't sync by default), so sync clients aren't racing Magpie for the database.

If you use Magpie on two PCs, each PC has its own separate `magpie.db`. Tag edits made on one PC don't appear on the other.

Magpie's own workshop

Everything Magpie needs lives here:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder has:

- `magpie.db` — the database described above. This is where your tags and titles are.
- Small **thumbnail images** so the grid loads without delay (`thumbs\` subfolder).
- A **log file** that helps if you ever run into trouble (`logs\app.log`).

The three golden rules

1. **Magpie never moves or modifies your original files.** They stay byte-for-byte the way they were.
2. **Magpie never uploads anything.** No internet, no cloud, no account.
3. **All your tags and titles are in one database.** Copy `magpie.db` and you've copied everything Magpie knows.

Backing up

Back up your `magpie.db` file (or the entire `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\` folder to also keep thumbnails and logs). That's your whole Magpie library in one file.

Your original photo folders don't need special backup treatment — they don't contain any Magpie data. Copying them elsewhere copies only the pixels, not the tags. If you move to a new PC and want your tags to come with you, copy `magpie.db` too.

Working with other tools

Magpie keeps your tags in its own database, not inside the files themselves. That has two implications for other tools:

- **The files themselves are never modified.** Every viewer and editor on your PC sees exactly the bytes the camera (or Photoshop, or Lightroom) originally produced.
- **Tags don't automatically sync between Magpie and Explorer / Lightroom.** If you want them to end up in the file, you'll need to write them out with the other tool as before — Magpie won't do that automatically.

Importing existing tags

If a photo already has tags in it (added earlier by Lightroom, Bridge, or the *Properties* → *Details* dialog in Explorer, or an older version of Magpie), Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan of that folder and imports them into its database.

- XMP `dc:subject`, Microsoft-Photo `MP:LastKeywordXMP`, and Windows Shell `System.Keywords` are all recognised.
- The imported title comes from XMP `dc:title` or `System.Title`.

After that first-scan import, Magpie treats its database as the truth. Later edits you make in Lightroom, Bridge, or Explorer will **not** show up in Magpie until you re-import the folder.

Refreshing after external edits

If you know a file was retagged outside Magpie and want to bring those tags back in, the simplest path is:

1. **Remove** the folder from Magpie (right-click it in the sidebar → *Remove from library*). Your files aren't touched.
2. **Add** the folder again. The first-scan import runs and picks up the current XMP / Explorer keywords for every file.

Anything you'd added *only* inside Magpie for that folder will be lost by this step, because Magpie doesn't write tags back into the files. Use it only when the external tool is the authoritative source.

In short

- Magpie doesn't fight other tools for control of your files.
- If Magpie is your primary tagging tool, everything just works.
- If your other tool is primary and you want its tags in Magpie, re-import that folder from time to time.

Keyboard shortcuts

You can do everything in Magpie with a mouse, but keyboard shortcuts make the whole thing much faster once you know them.

Picking files

Shortcut	What it does
Click	Pick one file
Ctrl + Click	Add or remove one file from your selection
Shift + Click	Pick everything between the last click and this one
Ctrl + A	Pick every file in the current view
Esc	Unpick everything

Moving around

Shortcut	What it does
Arrow keys	Move the cursor around the grid
Home / End	Jump to the first / last file
Page Up / Page Down	Jump one screen up or down

Titles and tags

Shortcut	What it does
Tab (in the title)	Save what you typed and move to the next field
Enter (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed

Shortcut	What it does
Space (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Comma (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Backspace (empty tag box)	Remove the last tag you added

Everyday actions

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + F	Jump to the search box at the top
Ctrl + R	Refresh every folder in your library
Delete	Send the selected files to the Recycle Bin
Shift + Delete	Delete the selected files permanently
F1	Open this manual

Layout

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + B	Show or hide the left-hand sidebar
Ctrl + D	Show or hide the details panel on the right
F11	Full-screen mode (great for browsing)

Troubleshooting

Most bumps you'll hit fall into one of the buckets below. If none of these matches your problem, Magpie keeps a diary in a log file that can help — the last section explains where to find it.

The app won't open

What happens: You double-click Magpie and either nothing happens or you get a “WebView2” error message.

Fix: Install the free **Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime** from Microsoft's website. It's a small download. Windows 11 already has it; Windows 10 usually gets it automatically through Windows Update.

Tags I added in File Explorer don't show up in Magpie

What happens: You right-click a file in File Explorer, add a tag under **Properties › Details**, but Magpie doesn't list it.

Why: Magpie's tag data lives in its own database, not inside the file. Explorer edits go into the file. Magpie reads those file tags **once**, on first scan of the folder, and then treats its database as the source of truth.

Fix: Right-click the folder in the sidebar and choose **Remove from library**, then add the folder again. The first scan re-imports whatever tags Explorer, Bridge, or Lightroom have put in the files. Any tags you'd already added in Magpie for that folder are lost by this step, so use it only when the other tool is the authoritative tagger.

Tags I added in Magpie don't show up in File Explorer

What happens: You add a tag in Magpie, open the file's properties in File Explorer, and the Tags row is empty.

Why: Magpie doesn't write into your files. Tags live only in Magpie's database.

If you need the tag inside the file (for example so it survives being sent to a friend by email), tag the file with Explorer's *Properties* → *Details* dialog directly, or with a tool like Adobe Bridge / digiKam that writes XMP. Magpie will pick that tag up the next time you re-add the folder to import fresh.

Files are missing from the grid

What happens: A folder has 500 files in File Explorer but only 480 appear in Magpie.

Common reasons:

- **Unusual file formats.** Magpie handles the ones listed on [Supported file formats](#). Others are skipped.
 - **Hidden files.** Files marked as Hidden or System in Windows are skipped on purpose.
 - **A previous scan hit an error.** Right-click the folder → **Rescan folder** to try again.
-

The folder shows “(offline)” in the sidebar

What happens: A folder that used to work now appears greyed-out with an *(offline)* label.

Why: Magpie couldn't reach the folder on disk. Usually this is because the drive is unplugged (external disk) or a network share is not reachable right now.

Fix: Plug the drive back in / reconnect to the network share. Click **Rescan** at the top of the window. The folder should come back online.

The app is slow / the grid stutters

What to try:

- **Wait for the first scan.** The very first time Magpie reads a folder it works your CPU hard making thumbnails. Give it a few minutes. Next time you open the app, it'll be instant.
- **Close other heavy apps.** Magpie uses your graphics card to draw the grid smoothly. If another app is eating that up, both apps suffer.

- **Restart Magpie.** Sometimes the simplest fix.
-

“Save failed” message

What happens: After adding a tag, a red **Save failed** message appears in the details panel.

Fix: Most common causes:

1. **Disk full.** The database is tiny but SQLite needs a few kilobytes free to write.
2. **Another Magpie window is running.** Close the other instance and try again — only one Magpie can safely write to the database at a time on the same PC.
3. **File permissions on %APPDATA%.** Very unusual. If your Windows account can’t write to its own `AppData\Roaming` folder, most apps won’t work.

The log file (see below) will tell you exactly what went wrong.

Resetting Magpie

If Magpie gets into a weird state and you want to start fresh:

1. Close Magpie.
2. Open File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar, and press Enter.
3. Delete `magpie.db` (or the whole folder — everything else can be regenerated).
4. Reopen Magpie. You start with an empty library; re-add your folders. Any tags that were embedded in the files themselves (by Explorer, Bridge, or Lightroom) come back automatically on first scan. Tags you’d only added inside Magpie are gone.

Tip: before step 3, copy `magpie.db` somewhere safe. That single file is your whole library backup.

Finding the log file

Magpie keeps a diary of everything it does at:

```
%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\logs\app.log
```

Open it in Notepad. The bottom of the file is the most recent activity. Lines beginning with **WARN** or **ERROR** are the interesting ones if something went wrong. This is the file to share (or paste into) if you ever report a bug.